# WOMEN SANS FRONTIERS

**At the INDIA TODAY Woman Summit, icons from politics, business, art and more talk shop and dissect the domains that defy feminist gains**

**Heated discussion on consent and Gen Z's role in politics**; eye-opening insight on gender disparity in the entertainment industry; inspiring tales of overcoming adversity from war widows and sport icons; sound financial and medical advice from industry experts; fine performances and fun banter, with an invested, inquisitive, predominantly female audience to top it: the INDIA TODAY Woman Summit held last week in Delhi had it all.

**ANUPRIYA PATEL**
***Union minister of state, health and family welfare; chemicals and fertilisers***

**Political parties are reluctant to give tickets to women candidates, thinking they are unwinnable. Unless you are from a politically established family, they always prefer a male candidate**

**We may differ in our perspectives, in our opinions, but we are all for this nation. We all want this nation to progress and become better. We may just feel that a different route should be adopted**

There were also some truth bombs. Anupriya Patel, Union minister of state for health and family welfare, as well as for chemicals and fertilisers, said that implementation of 33 per cent reservation for women in Parliament isn't a one-stop solution for increased political representation. For real change, the reluctance to field women candidates needs to change. Being a woman politician, she noted, means constantly having to prove yourself. "People really find it hard to trust in your abilities... You have to make extra efforts to win their trust," she added.

Indian women are breaking barriers across domains. Lt Col Ravinder Jit (Romi) Randhawa, India's first Veer Nari, spoke of how more women are entering the armed forces in roles they were once exempted from. Manisha Malhotra, president of the Inspire Institute of Sport, noted how our sportswomen have a greater "fight and hunger", which has helped them inch closer to demanding world standards. Kuchipudi artist Yamini Reddy recalled how women have taken the reins of what was once a male-dominated field.

Others like Ruchikaa Kapoor Sheikh, director, original films, Netflix India, believe that women have to be each other's biggest cheerleaders. At Netflix, she noted, one in every five original films was helmed by a woman, and how substantial roles were etched for actresses to challenge existing stereotypes.

Findings from INDIA TODAY's recent survey on consent led to a range of viewpoints, from conditioning of girls in childhood to how fear of reprisal at workplace deters women from filing complaints. But times, they are changin'. Ranjana Kumari, director, Centre for Social Research, noted that while it is true that girls are often raised to accommodate and boys brought up with entitlement, she has seen attitudes change, especially among the younger generation which asks: "Why me, why not him?" In that simple question lie vast grounds for hope. ■

***—Suhani Singh***

*Photograph by* CHANDRADEEP KUMAR